## Object Blog for the Department of History

The Object Blog is a short blog focused on a material object that can be associated with Victorian London. Ideally the blog should focus on a surviving object that can be authenticated by an archive or museum but objects from personal connections are also acceptable.

Module advice on writing Object Blogs include these pointers:

- Present information concisely and clearly – include key facts but also engaging anecdotes.
- Write simply and clearly – avoid long sentences. Write in short paragraphs, and use single sentence paragraphs if this is appropriate.
- Give a sense of source material – but with a 'light touch' – sources can be indicated through hyperlinks for example.
- Where possible, include images – contrasting images can work well. Make the blog **ACCESSIBLE**.
- Find a new angle on your subject or take a creative approach to engage your audience.
- Also see list of shared ideas for a good blog on Moodle and tips for writing history blogs, here: https://historyatkingston.wordpress.com/2017/03/29/writing-good-history-blog-posts-some-brief-guidance/

**MARKER'S COMMENTS**

**Victorian Londoners and their Beloved Cats**

*Strengths*

Well done – this is a really fantastic blog, packed with great source material and beautifully presented. The blog is clearly and well written throughout in a fun and chatty tone that is likely to appeal to a general audience. The discussion of changing attitudes to cats as pets in the 19thc and the role of class shows a good wider knowledge of the period and good work with the secondary literature. The range of primary material you have identified, linking cats to Victorian London, is really impressive and a great feature of the blog. The images and objects have also been effectively analysed and their significance has been clearly explained for a general audience. The presentation of the blog is fabulous – featuring a wide range of images, a novel format and creative use of colour and fonts.

*For Development*

While you sketch the general context well you could have been a little bit more nuanced in your discussion of overall change in attitudes to cats. While cats do become more acceptable as pets they were cherished by many owners before the 19thc and in families across the social scale. The big change is the arrival of pedigree that increases their economic and social value. It would also have been good to hear a little more about the materiality of the mummified cat and rat – how did they end up in this condition?

Overall – An excellent piece of work – well done!

Victorian Pets Collection - November 2022

By: Lucy Glazzard

# Victorian Londoners and Their Beloved Cats

## Taxidermy, Art and Mummification– Feline presence in Victorian London

### The Cat Show of 1871

Fulmer Zalda – The Champion Show Cat of 1895

Cats in the 1860s had a bad reputation. EarlyVictorian society wasn't quite so doting on their feline companions as we are today - their primary function was for vermin population control. Harrison Weir changed this; a devout *'feline evangelist'*, he is credited with the creation of the first 'Cat Show' in Crystal Palace. He devised a standard that judges could hold the fancy-felines to and divided them by breed and size. The show was a great success, Victorian perceptions of cats changed and it was the first competitive cat show in London. 520 cats were entered into the competition and more than 20,000 spectators came to witness the feline entertainment.

### Oliver the Taxidermy Cat

This sweet brown cat *(right)* (*a rather uniquely cute example of Victorian taxidermy*) was owned by a family in *Charlton, London* by the end of the 19th century. Clearly treasured and adored by his family; Oliver is presented with a yellow ribbon and lovingly preserved with a bouquet of flowers. The Museum of London gives a possible explanation for the presence of the flowers and ribbon – it is believed that Oliver was a wedding gift. Taxidermy was an expensive and time consuming

Oliver the Cat from the Museum of London's 'Cats through London's history'

hobby to pursue, so whoever the cat was presumably gifted to was important to the family. Oliver is evidence of a growing trend in pet-keeping for the late Victorians. Many cats before Oliver were strays on the streets of London with a knack for rat-catching; they weren't the proud possession of a London Middle-Class family to be expensively preserved and cherished. The heart-warming family cat hopefully introduces a new perspective on the value of pets in late 19th century London.

## The cameos of cats in London's Victorian art collections

Material Culture from Victorian London can tell us a lot about how the everyday person felt about cats. Many depictions of cats exist in art from the nineteenth century, and these felines are portrayed as either friend or foe in many works. Below are just a few examples -

### 'The Intruder' by Sir Edwin Landseer - 1848

This is an engraving made from the original painting by Sir Edwin Henry Landseer. It was engraved in London by H.G. Beckswith. The engraving depicts a confrontation between a cat and a dog in a barn, where a rat can be seen in the bottom right corner. It is perhaps not too obtuse to say that the dog has chosen the wrong victim. This depiction may be a positive message for felines in Victorian London; the dog is not a very successful rat catcher or intelligent creature. The biggest winner here though is most likely the rat.

## 'Hide and Seek' *(right)* & 'New Lodgers' *(below)* 1884 – By Henriette Ronner

Another example of engravings, this time published in London by Frederick Hunter, depicting the original art-work of Dutch artist Henriette Ronner. The depiction of cats playing reflects the shift in Late-Victorian appreciation of cats as pets. Rather refreshing and light-hearted, they shed light onto an aspect of Victorian London's society that is surprisingly positive.

## Stray cats in Victorian London – useful or a pest?

To end on a less cheery tone, which is perhaps more fitting for a dive into the history of Victorian London, it is important to look at the position of cats that weren't held at a family pet status. This mummified cat and rat duo were found at the London Docks in the 1890s and are held at The Museum of London today. Cats were encouraged to roam freely along the Thames Docks in an attempt to control the vermin that consumed edible goods within the warehouses. Although preserved in a more morbid manner than the likes of Oliver, this mummified cat exemplifies dockyard environments in Victorian London – and the presence of these cats helped to enforce sanitation by catching vermin. Some mousers were even put on the payroll – the Post Office gave up a shilling a week for its working felines. Although grotesque, the cat and rat show the role of cats as workers and valuable members of Victorian Dock Life.

Mummified Cat – London Docks, 1890s

Where to see examples of Victorian Cats (and Oliver)

The Victoria & Albert Museum - Cromwell Road, London SW7 2RL England

The Museum of London - Museum of London, 150 London Wall, EC2Y 5HN